

Heart Disease

Heart disease includes many diseases that affect your heart, but coronary artery disease (CAD) is the most common and familiar one. Heart disease can lead to a heart attack, heart failure, cardiac arrest, stroke and organ damage. Healthy habits, medicines and procedures can prevent or treat CAD and other heart diseases.

What Is Heart Disease?

Heart disease describes a variety of issues that can affect your heart. [Coronary artery disease](#) (CAD) is the most common type. CAD, also known as coronary heart disease, can make your arteries narrow and lead to a heart attack. Heart disease can also affect your heart muscle, valves or electrical system. The symptoms you have and the treatments you get depend on the type of heart disease you have.

When your heart isn't working well, it has trouble sending enough blood, oxygen and nutrients to your body. In a way, your heart delivers the fuel that keeps your body running. If your heart can't deliver that fuel, it affects everything your body's systems do.

Lifestyle changes and medications can keep your heart healthy and lower your chances of getting heart disease.

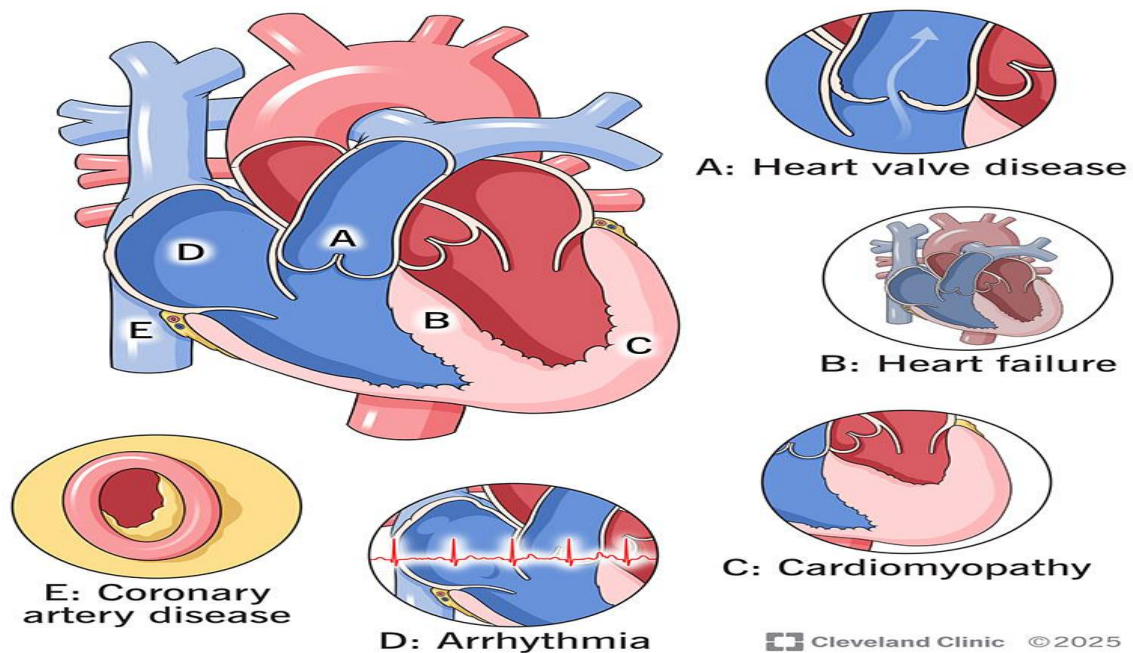
Heart disease is the top cause of death in the United States in people from most ethnic backgrounds.

Types of heart disease

Heart disease types include:

- **Coronary artery disease:** Fatty deposits make your heart's blood vessels narrow.
- **Arrhythmias:** Abnormal heart rhythms keep your heart from beating in a coordinated way.
- [Heart valve diseases](#): Valves that are too narrow or don't close right reduce blood flow.
- [Cardiomyopathy](#): Stiff or thickened heart muscle can't pump blood well.
- [Heart failure](#): Your heart can't pump blood well enough to keep up with your body's needs.
- **Congenital heart disease:** Problems with how your heart formed before birth prevent normal blood flow.
- **Pericardial issues:** A stiff or inflamed sac ([pericardium](#)) around your heart presses on your heart.

Types of heart disease



Symptoms and Causes

Symptoms of heart disease

The first symptoms of heart disease include chest pain, shortness of breath, swelling in your legs, fatigue and dizziness/fainting. But you can have different signs of heart disease depending on what's wrong. Heart disease symptoms may include:

- Pounding or racing heart (palpitations)
- Sweating
- Neck pain
- Heartburn or indigestion
- Nausea or vomiting
- Trouble sleeping
- Exercise intolerance
- Fever

Heart disease causes

Issues with your heart, like muscle scarring or injury or blocked arteries can cause heart disease. Different types of heart disease have different causes. Other causes of heart disease include:

- [Genetic issues](#)

- Kidney problems
- Infections, including those outside your heart
- [Thyroid](#) problems
- [Autoimmune diseases](#)
- Pregnancy complications
- Aging
- Certain medications, like [chemotherapy](#)
- Use of addictive substances
- [High blood pressure](#)

Risk factors

Heart disease may be more likely to happen to you if you have certain risk factors. Risk factors for heart disease include conditions like high cholesterol, high blood pressure, Type 2 diabetes or substance use disorder. You're also in a high-risk group if you have a BMI (body mass index) higher than 25 (having overweight). Having heart disease in your biological family raises your risk, and so does using tobacco products, being inactive and eating unhealthy foods.

You can lower your risk by managing these conditions, being more physically active, giving up tobacco and eating healthier.

Complications of this condition

Some types of heart disease can lead to other kinds of heart disease. Complications of heart disease — many of which are life-threatening — include:

- Heart attack
- Heart failure
- Cardiomyopathy
- [Stroke](#)
- Abnormal heart rhythms
- [Cardiogenic shock](#)
- [Cardiac arrest](#)
- Heart valve disease
- [Pulmonary hypertension](#)

- Damage to your kidneys or liver

Diagnosis and Tests

How doctors diagnose this condition

A provider can make a heart disease diagnosis after doing a physical exam, hearing about your symptoms and learning about your personal and biological family health history. They'll also perform diagnostic tests, like:

- [Electrocardiogram](#) (EKG or ECG)
- Ambulatory monitors
- [Echocardiogram](#)
- [Cardiac computerized tomography \(CT\)](#)
- Heart magnetic resonance imaging (MRI)
- Blood tests to check your cholesterol level and other substances
- Stress test
- [Cardiac catheterization](#)

Management and Treatment

How is heart disease treated?

Heart disease treatments depend on your heart issue. Your healthcare provider may ask you to make changes to your daily life, take medication or have surgery.

Heart disease treatments may include:

- **Lifestyle changes:** This could consist of cutting saturated fats from your meals, stopping the use of tobacco products or starting a walking program.
- **Medicine:** You can lower blood pressure and cholesterol with medicine. Also, certain medications can help with heart failure or abnormal heart rhythms. Always take these prescriptions the way your provider tells you to.
- **Surgeries or procedures:** You may need open-heart surgery, minimally invasive surgery or an [ablation](#). Other procedures include catheterization, device placement or [cardioversion](#).
- **Cardiac rehab:** This supervised program can strengthen your heart after a heart attack. With nutritional advice and monitored exercise, it provides extra support for changing your lifestyle.

Recovery time

Depending on the surgery or procedure you have, your recovery can take a few days to many weeks. You may only need a few days to recover from minor procedures. But you may need two to four weeks to recover from minimally invasive surgery and six to 12 weeks to recover from open-heart surgery.

When should I see my healthcare provider?

If you have a biological family history of heart disease, you may want to ask your provider if you have other risk factors. If you do, you can make a plan to help [prevent heart disease](#).

Contact your provider if you have heart disease symptoms. Call your local emergency number if you suddenly experience chest pain, pressure, heaviness or discomfort, fainting or shortness of breath.

You may want to ask your healthcare provider:

- What kind of heart disease do I have?
- Is my family at risk for this type of disease?
- What's the best treatment for me?

Outlook / Prognosis

What can I expect if I have heart disease?

Medications and/or procedures can help people who have various types of heart diseases. It's easier to treat most types of heart disease if you get an early diagnosis instead of waiting for symptoms to get worse. Many people can live full lives when they follow their healthcare provider's treatment plan.

Is there anything I can do to feel better?

If you have coronary artery disease (the most common kind of heart disease), you can improve your health by making changes to your daily life. This may include reducing how much salt and saturated fat you eat and increasing how active you are. A provider may also recommend taking medicine to lower your cholesterol and blood pressure.

Prevention

Can heart disease be prevented?

You can prevent some kinds of heart diseases in these ways:

- Reach and stay at a weight that's healthy for you.
- Manage conditions like diabetes, high blood pressure and high cholesterol.
- Get at least 30 to 60 minutes of exercise per day on most days.
- Decrease your stress level.

- Sleep seven to nine hours every night.
- Eat foods that are unprocessed and low in salt and saturated fat.
- Don't use any tobacco products.
- Limit how many beverages you drink that contain alcohol.

Medications for Heart Health

Several types of medications can help manage heart conditions and improve cardiovascular health. Here are some commonly prescribed medications and their roles:

Antihypertensives:

- **ACE Inhibitors (e.g., lisinopril, enalapril):** These medications relax blood vessels, lower blood pressure, and reduce the workload on the heart.
- **Beta-Blockers (e.g., metoprolol, atenolol):** Beta-blockers slow the heart rate and reduce blood pressure, making it easier for the heart to pump blood.
- **Calcium Channel Blockers (e.g., amlodipine, diltiazem):** These drugs relax the blood vessels and lower blood pressure.
- **Diuretics (e.g., hydrochlorothiazide, furosemide):** Diuretics help eliminate excess sodium and water from the body, reducing blood pressure and swelling.

Cholesterol-Lowering Medications:

- **Statins (e.g., atorvastatin, simvastatin):** Statins lower LDL cholesterol levels and reduce the risk of heart attack and stroke.
- **Ezetimibe:** This medication reduces the absorption of cholesterol from the intestine.

Anticoagulants and Antiplatelets:

- **Aspirin:** Low-dose aspirin can prevent blood clots, reducing the risk of heart attack and stroke.
- **Warfarin, Clopidogrel:** These medications prevent blood clots by thinning the blood.

Heart Failure Medications:

- **Digoxin:** Helps improve the strength and efficiency of the heart.
- **Aldosterone Antagonists (e.g., spironolactone):** These medications help reduce symptoms of heart failure.

Lifestyle Changes for Cardiovascular Health

Medications are crucial for managing heart conditions, but lifestyle changes are equally important. Here are some tips to support your cardiovascular wellness:

Healthy Diet:

- **Eat Heart-Healthy Foods:** Focus on a diet rich in fruits, vegetables, whole grains, lean proteins, and healthy fats. Foods like salmon, nuts, berries, and leafy greens are particularly beneficial.
- **Reduce Sodium Intake:** Limit your consumption of salty foods and use herbs and spices to flavor your meals.
- **Avoid Trans Fats and Reduce Saturated Fats:** Choose healthier fats, such as those found in olive oil and avocados.

Regular Exercise:

- **Stay Active:** Aim to include moderate-intensity aerobic exercise, such as brisk walking or cycling, per week.
- **Incorporate Strength Training:** Include activities like weightlifting or resistance band exercises on a weekly basis.

Maintain a Healthy Weight:

Achieve and Maintain a Healthy BMI: A balanced diet and regular exercise can help you reach and maintain a healthy weight, reducing the strain on your heart.

Quit Smoking:

Smoking Cessation: If you smoke, quitting is one of the best things you can do for your heart. Our pharmacy offers resources and support to help you quit smoking.

Manage Stress:

Practice Stress-Reduction Techniques: Activities like yoga, meditation, and deep-breathing exercises can help reduce stress and improve heart health.

Limit Alcohol Consumption:

Drink in Moderation: If you drink alcohol, do so in moderation. For men, this means up to two drinks per day, and for women, up to one drink per day.

How Spartan Pharmacists Can Help

Our pharmacists are here to support your cardiovascular health journey through:

- **Medication Counseling:** We provide detailed information about your heart medications, including how to take them, potential side effects, and interactions with other drugs.
- **Synchronized Medication Delivery:** If you take multiple medications a month, we can help you align your medications to receive one monthly delivery through

our [SyncRX](#) and [free delivery](#) programs. There are some medications excluded from this program. Call or stop into our office to schedule this feature to help you stay well.

Simple Steps for Better Cardiovascular Health

Maintaining a healthy heart is essential for overall well-being, and there are many steps you can take to support cardiovascular health. Lifestyle changes such as eating a balanced diet, engaging in regular physical activity, managing stress, and getting enough sleep can all contribute to better heart health. Additionally, medications and supplements may play a role in managing blood pressure, cholesterol, and other heart-related conditions.